Research Statement **Patrick A. Testa**

I am an applied microeconomist studying how migration, ethnoracial violence, and other demographic shocks shape economic and political outcomes at both the micro and macro levels. My research cuts across multiple fields, including labor, urban, and public economics, as well as economic history and political economy. This work has been published in various top journals, including the *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, the *Review of Economic Studies*, the *Economic Journal*, the *Journal of Public Economics*, and the *Journal of Economic History*. Recently published papers of mine include Testa and Williams (2026), on the role of local media in fomenting racial violence in the post-Reconstruction South, and Bazzi, Ferrara, Fiszbein, Pearson, and Testa (2025), on the role of migration by Southern white elites after the Civil War in shaping the political economy of the American West.

Agenda 1: Migration and Displacement

Migration, of kinds both voluntary and forced, has shaped and reshaped the United States repeatedly over its history—to say nothing of global impacts. The largest share of my research agenda is dedicated to studying this process, and most of my work connects back to it in some way.

Voluntary migration. The story of the United States is one of migrants. Yet, this story does not end at our border. Rather, waves of internal migration have continually remade the demographic fabric of the country, with implications at both the micro and macro levels. Of the papers listed on my CV, over half are in some way related to this history. I highlight two of these works.

In "The Confederate Diaspora" (*Review of Economic Studies*, Bazzi, Ferrara, Fiszbein, Pearson, and Testa, forthcoming), we propose a framework for understanding how migrants interact with their destination communities. While they may assimilate into local norms and practices, migrants sometimes preserve cultural traditions across generations and reshape their communities in long-lasting ways. For empirical evidence, we examine a wave of migration involving around 1 million former Confederate households, including many former slaveholders, in the decades following the Civil War. We identify short- and long-run effects on local institutions and cultural norms, which emerged and persisted in the places where those migrants settled, with implications for understanding patterns of racial violence and animus over the longer term. The paper has garnered wide media coverage, including in *NBC News* and *USA Today*, and has 60 citations.

The complementary "The Other Great Migration: Southern Whites and the New Right" (*Quarterly Journal of Economics*, Bazzi, Ferrara, Fiszbein, Pearson, and Testa, 2023) focuses on the macro-level implications of these (and subsequent) internal migrations. We show how millions of White migrants leaving the U.S. South in the first half of the 20th century reshaped the electoral landscape nationwide. These migrants tended to be racially and religiously conservative, and their arrival outside the South expanded the conservative voter base, hastening partisan realignment

and bolstering the nascent New Right movement during the second half of the century. Beyond just augmenting the electorate, migrant communities influenced non-Southerners by building evangelical churches, diffusing new forms of media, and intermarrying with local populations. The paper received coverage in *The Economist*, *NPR*, and the *Washington Post*, and currently has 140 citations.

Forced migration. My research on forced migration demonstrates how violent displacement can reverberate through origin economies for generations. In "The Economic Legacy of Expulsion: Lessons from Post-war Czechoslovakia" (*Economic Journal*, Testa, 2021), I study the expulsion of roughly three million German-speaking individuals from the Czech border regions (the "Sudetenland") after the Second World War. Using the discontinuity in ethnic composition along the Sudetenland's historical boundary for identification, I show that the expulsion created persistent gaps in population density, sectoral composition, and educational attainment. The expulsion did not merely replace Germans with Czechs. Rather, it set in motion selective resettlements and extraction of capital that culminated in long-term urban decay and human-capital decline. Initially a chapter in my dissertation, the paper now has 63 citations.

A working project, "The Geography of Demographic Composition in the United States," with Bazzi, Chyn, Ferrara, Fiszbein, and Pearson investigates historical expulsion events in the context of the United States. Many such episodes of displacement are well known, including the Tulsa Race Massacre. At the same time, numerous smaller yet no less important episodes remain poorly understood if not forgotten. With the aid of large language models and a vast team of research assistants, we are actively parsing millions of newspaper articles for references to such events. By combining those records with full-count U.S. Census data, we will build a novel, comprehensive database of minority expulsion across U.S. towns between 1870 and 1940 and, in turn, study the effects of these events on both the places and people involved. This work is funded by grants from the National Science Foundation and the Russell Sage Foundation, alongside several smaller sources. We anticipate that we will have constructed the dataset by summer 2027, at which point we will begin the full analysis.

Data infrastructure for scientists. To facilitate research on spatial dynamics, I have worked with colleagues to develop a publicly available set of county-to-county and county-to-congressional-district crosswalks (*Historical Methods*, Ferrara, Testa, and Zhou, 2024). To improve upon area-based weights used in prior crosswalks, which may misallocate population flows when urbanization is heterogeneous, we also produce population-based weights for mapping county-level data across Censuses as well as counties to congressional districts. These crosswalks match official Census data more closely than those using area-based weights. The dataset is already being used by researchers and policymakers to study demographic change, voting patterns, and economic development, and the corresponding paper already has 100 citations.

Agenda 2: Ethnoracial Violence

My ongoing work with Bazzi, Chyn, Ferrara, Fiszbein, and Pearson, described above, builds on Testa and Williams (*Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 2026), "Political Foundations of Racial Violence in the Post-Reconstruction South." The latter shows how lynching in the post-Reconstruction U.S. South was tied to the local performance of the Democratic Party in presidential elections. Using a regression discontinuity design based on close presidential vote shares, we find that Southern counties where Democrats lost the popular vote between 1880 and 1900 were nearly twice as likely to experience Black lynchings in the following four years. The effect runs through party-affiliated newspapers: in such counties where Democrats lost, local elites responded by amplifying narratives of Black-committed crime. These stories tended to precipitate local lynching events, pointing to the strategic use of racial violence by Democratic elites in response to the growing threat of Black power.

Agenda 3: Race and U.S. Electoral Politics

Continuing my work on electoral realignment in the 20th century (Bazzi, Ferrara, Fiszbein, Pearson, and Testa, 2023), a new solo-authored working paper, "The Winner Premium," studies realignment as a dynamic process, with place-specific electoral outcomes guiding subsequent political investment by political parties and allied groups. Following the same empirical design as Testa and Williams (2026), counties where Democrats narrowly won the presidential vote between 1940 and 1970 subsequently experienced pronounced increases in Democratic local officeholding and voter support. The initial mechanism is behavioral in nature: examining local post-election news coverage, I find that such outcomes were treated as binary, with winners celebrated and losers mourned. The effects—largest in urban, Black, and union areas—thereafter operate through political investment, including advertising, direct voter outreach, and civil rights organizing. Aggregated across a competitive map, this premium plausibly shaped the trajectory of realignment nationally, helping to reorganize Democratic Party politics around minority and urban voters by the 1970s.

Together with Testa and Williams (2026), the two cases serve as two sides of one coin: the same ranking signal that told locally powerful actors where to suppress an emerging opposition in the post-Reconstruction South told the same party where to direct new voter outreach almost a century later in the country's increasingly-diverse urban North.